

FINE LIVING
HOTEL

THE MYSTIC MANSION

THE Park Hotels' foray into Chettinad with THE Lotus Palace, a heritage property that is a marvel of restoration and quiet luxury.

By Amit Dixit

I've always been curious about Chettinad's mansions. The luxurious family homes of a wealthy mercantile community came on the tourism map only a few decades ago. Now there's a new—but very old and venerable—kid on the block, by THE Park Hotels group. THE Park Hotels' pivot into the heritage hotel space began modestly with The Denmark Tavern in Serampore, but has gathered pace with two dramatic openings in quick succession. One is Ran Baas The Palace, an elegant heritage hotel nestled inside the Qila Mubarak in Patiala. The other is THE Lotus Palace Chettinad, which, with its maximalist aesthetic, is the prettiest of the trio. Being a heritage junkie, I had to check it out.

Leaving Trichy Airport, we were greeted by a rugged landscape, mellowed by low-hanging clouds and a gently setting sun. The road was smooth and the cab made good time to our destination—the sleepy hamlet of Kanadukathan, deep inside Chettiar country. Centuries ago, this is where the Nattukottai Chettiars, an enterprising trading community with a global footprint, set down roots in over 90 villages. Marvels of urban planning and palatial architecture, three of these village clusters have earned themselves a UNESCO tag. Over the years, a few of the mansions have opened their doors to privileged guests who can get a taste of the wealthy merchant life—for a night or two.

It was dark by the time I arrived. The 230-year-old Lotus Palace was lit up like a bride. Following the plan of most Chettiar mansions, it comprised a *thinnai* or verandah, followed by a succession of courtyards, with residential quarters arranged

